GLIMPSES OF OUR CINEMATIC HISTORY



SPLASH OF COLOUR

In 1952, Mehboob made *Aan*, **the first colour film** shot in 16mm Kodachrome. By the mid-1950s, V. Shantaram was making optimum use of colour (*Jhanak Jhanak Payal Baaje, Navrang*). Shammi Kapoor's *Junglee* was the first film made in Eastmancolor.

AROUND THE WORLD

Though ***Naaz* (1954)** offered a glimpse of the world beyond India with shots of London and Cairo, its actors, Ashok Kumar and Nalini Jaywant, didn't get to travel to the locations. That honour went to Raj Kapoor, whose production *Sangam* (1964) kickstarted the trend of shooting abroad to film both songs and scenes.

THE ANGRY YOUNG MAN



As India endured its first brush with authoritarianism in the Emergency, writers Salim Khan and Javed Akhtar collaborated to capture the fury and frustration of the average Indian. **Amitabh Bachchan embodied that persona** in films like *Deewaar*.

THE GOLDEN AGE OF TELEVISION

दूरदर्शन
सत्यम् शिवम् सुन्दरम्

Thanks largely to the serialised epics and filmmakers like Shyam Benegal, Basu Chatterjee and Kundan Shah creating shows for Doordarshan, its **viewership went up from about 15 million in 1982 to an estimated 75 million** by the end of the decade.

THE MULTIPLEX BOOM

In **1997, Ajay Bijli**, who'd inherited Priya cinema from his father, partnered with Australia's Village Roadshow to start Priya Village Roadshow (PVR) with a four-screen complex in Saket, Delhi. Soon, multiplexes became the norm and giant single-screen halls the anomaly.



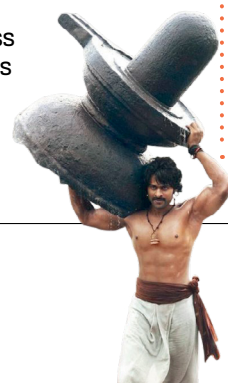


INDUSTRY TAG

The film sector was **granted industry status in 2000**, enabling filmmakers to seek bank credit to fund their passion projects and reducing their dependence on 'black money' finance and underworld ties. It also ushered in the era of corporatisation, leading to the advent of foreign studios.

THE PAN-INDIA FILM

Telugu filmmaker **S.S. Rajamouli's *Bahubali* films (2015, 2017)** broke linguistic boundaries and became a pan-India sensation. The franchise's success emboldened others to dub their films in Hindi and reach out to a wider audience.



THE STREAMING REVOLUTION

As cinemas across India downed their shutters in **2020 during the Covid pandemic,** Indians turned to streaming platforms and were spoilt for choice. Freed from the diktats of the box office, filmmakers turned to long-format narratives and studios set up digital content branches to meet the soaring demand.

technological leap with the advent of colour, even as the hero began to dance and romance, also in foreign locations. In the 1970s and '80s, however, the rage and anguish of the marginalised Indian found expression in the works of filmmakers like Shyam Benegal, Govind Nihalani and Saeed Mirza. The 1980s also saw the Hindi film industry compete with television for eyeballs. But before one could say TV had killed the movie star, the trio of Khans—Aamir, Salman and Shah Rukh—entered the scene. Their arrival almost coincided with economic liberalisation, which led to films celebrating the aspirational Indian like Simran in *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jaayenge*, who thought nothing of requesting her family for a Euro trip just before her wedding.

The 1990s saw the advent of satellite television, which ended Doordarshan's monopoly and created an abundance of opportunities for a new generation of filmmakers, technicians and actors. This 'MTV generation' began seeking Hollywood films and even TV shows from the US, prompting cinema owners to up the audio-visual experience. Filmmaking saw yet more change with the entry of the multiplex. For every formulaic mainstream entertainer, there was also an 'indie' film that discarded filmy tropes and drew audiences with ingenious storytelling. More Indian films began making an impact at international film festivals. The arrival of YouTube in India in 2008 was another gamechanger as Indians began enjoying short-form content for free. Less than a decade later came subscriber video-on-demand platforms, with Hotstar, SonyLIV and Netflix offering original long-format content from across the world on mobiles. Thus was born a language-agnostic audience, open to watch dubbed or subtitled content. Perhaps why Rocky from *K.G.F* is not a Kannada film hero, but an Indian one. ■